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Dick Sherman

Dick Sherman is a loyal alumnus of Hamilton College's Class of 1953. His jazz passion found the perfect outlet on campus with the Catatonic Five and he speaks proudly of his role as drummer and leader of Hamilton's Alumni All-Stars.

Dick was interviewed in Clinton, New York on June 1, 2006 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in the Browsing Room on campus. I'm very pleased to have Dick Sherman with me today, class of '53.

DS: Yes.

MR: And I can call you Sherm on camera?

DS: Please do.

MR: Okay Sherm. It's a pleasure to have you here on your annual trek to Hamilton for you guys.

DS: Over fifty years, Monk.

MR: Fifty years, that's amazing. And it says here, in print, that you are the nation's longest playing alumni band.

DS: We are.

MR: Yeah. That's great.

DS: Yup. There is a band that has played almost as long, Eli's Chosen Six from Yale. But I play with some of those guys all the time and they do not donate any jazz to their alma mater, they play less frequently and they are paid, and extremely well paid for their work.

MR: Wow. You know Roswell Rudd, the trombone player, mentioned that group.

DS: Yes.

MR: That he played with them I think.

DS: Well I specifically talked about Dick Voight, who is the piano player, who helped me take the survey so I could make the claim that we are the longest playing band, and the cornet player was Lee Lorenz, who is the cartoonist for the *New Yorker*, a multi-talented man, he's also a writer, and he plays in my Manhattan band, the Gotham Jazz Men. And we play every Thursday, a noontime concert free, and thirty plus years. We are in our thirty-first year donating that jazz. And I heard Phil say, in response to your question, is how come people's chops are in shape and why are they up to snuff when they come here? Well we each have our own local band, such as the Gotham Jazz Men in Manhattan

around the country playing in their local bands, then they convene at Hamilton and then we really have fun.

MR: Yeah. And you guys do have fun.

DS: We have fun, and the band is a bunch of humorists. They're very, very funny. I've played in many bands, Monk, over the years. This bunch, every one of them is a live wire. They're funny. We exchange emails and mailings and they're always hilarious, on any subject. For instance, Donny Andre, our banjoist, wanted to be sure that when we take up our residence for this next few days in an ex-fraternity house, that we would each have a private bathroom. And by George that was very difficult for Laurie Russell, our Alumni Affairs honcho, to arrange. But she said, "I'll keep trying." And I kept hearing from Donny Andre, "Are we going to get our private bathrooms?" Well finally at the last minute she said, "You're going to be in the old Psi U house, which is known as the Skenandoa House, and guess what, you're getting private loos, each one will have one. So I announced this to the members of the band in a poem called "A Private Loo," and they seemed to enjoy it. That's the thing. We don't require anything fancy or anything particularly noteworthy to be a subject for humor.

MR: Do you happen to have this poem memorized?

DS: No I don't believe I do.

MR: Oh, well we'll just have to do Interview Part II then where we'll feature a reading.

DS: Yeah. But any subject. Even bad health. My wife and I underwent serious illnesses at the very end of last year and the beginning of this one. She had two congestive heart failure attacks, hospitalized, quadruple bypass. The same day that she had quadruple bypass I was diagnosed with prostate cancer. So it was not a happy day. And the men in the Alumni All-Stars sent us flowers and a get well card. And the get well card, being cheap, it didn't say to Dick or to Betty, it said "Get Well Quick." So I sent them a poem chiding them for their cheapness and saying "you could have at least specified a name or two." So I ended up, that one I can recall, I ended up saying — well I claim that I can remember it — I can't. Well I'll think about it and get back to it later.

MR: Well it will come to you.

DS: It will.

MR: And we'll revisit that. Well you are feeling better now, you look great.

DS: Yeah. I recovered by means of radiation treatment. And it was not the seed implants, it was the beam radiation. A doctor introduced himself to me at the South Side Hospital where I went 38 times, every day, five days a week. You lie on an MRI type bed and this thing is beamed at you, and he introduced himself as the guy that was handling the beam, and I said, "I hope it's not Jim Beam." And he said, "No, no, no I'm usually off on the

MR: It sounds like a good match of doctors. Good. What brought you to Hamilton in 1949?

DS: '49. My father was a dentist. In those days you didn't go to a liberal arts college, you just went right to dental school from high school. He had heard about this college and he was so impressed with this campus that he wanted me to come here and brought me up, and I was interviewed by Sid Bennett, the Director of Admissions, and I'm very happy I came here. And one of the happiest things is the Catatonic Five. That was remarkable. I achieved some honors. I was elected the President of my class, selected the President of my fraternity, I was a member of the Student Council, but of all those things it was being the drummer in the Catatonic Five that pleased me the most, and helped me the most the rest of my life.

MR: How so?

DS: Lawyering is not always the most pleasant thing to do and I had this pastime of playing drums in jazz bands. And I so enjoyed that that it got me through being a lawyer. Now I'm through being a lawyer and just playing jazz, so I still play in New York every week and with several other bands, so it's a pleasure. But it was Hamilton College that got me started.

MR: You played drums when you came here?

DS: Not jazz. I played in the fireman's band and the high school bands and the marching bands. But it wasn't until I came here that I played jazz. I loved jazz but it was always listening to recordings. I used to listen to Ted Husing on Saturday mornings, the old famous sportscaster.

MR: Husing?

DS: H-U-S-I-N-G. He lost his sight and he continued to broadcast on the radio. And he was a great lover of Eddie Condon and so I used to listen Saturday mornings when I was a kid in my mother's car to Ted Husings' broadcast of Eddie Condon, Wild Bill Davison, Cutty Cutshall. And I used to get so excited by that music I wanted to roll myself up into a ball and shove myself into the radio in the dashboard of the car. I just loved it. And when I came to Hamilton I already was predisposed to Dixieland and I walked, as a freshman, across the Quadrangle and I heard some jazz coming out of one window. I think it was the Carnegie dorm. John Fell was the clarinetist in the Fallacious Five. He was playing and Jim Collier was with him, the trombone player.

MR: Oh and the author, the future author.

DS: Yeah. And he's the present member of my Gotham Jazz men in Manhattan. I recruited him to play trombone with us.

MR: Okay.

DS: And anyway, that entire band, which I became aware of by listening to these sounds

Silliman Hall. And the band at that time was Bob Krompart on cornet, Collier on trombone, John Fell was the clarinetist, the pianist was Pete Zeeveld, and Mike Beldock, who had a distinguished career as an attorney and still does, was the drummer in the band. And anyway I used to just sit there with my freshman beanie on and listen to these old men.

MR: Yeah, they seemed—

DS: They seemed so old to me. They tolerated my presence with my beanie, and then they graduated. And so I decided I'll form my own band. So it took me a year or two to round up the co-founders. I got Emerson Brown and Derry Hall. Derry Hall was a pianist and a guitarist. But as it turned out we needed a trombonist so he taught himself trombone. And we had Ron Jabaul of the Alpha Del house, he was the cornetist, Dave Barbour was at Theta Del, he was the pianist, and his only failing was that he had to read music. And he was the only one in the band that could read music, and he needed the music. And you talked a bit about alcohol before, and we were all pretty heavy drinkers. And when we played a gig we were never paid in cash in those days, this was early fifties, '50, '51, '52. And by '52 we had a good solid band and everybody got paid when we had a gig, of a quart of bourbon.

MR: No kidding.

DS: It was cheaper, and it was Blue Chip Bourbon as I recall. And in that band we had Emerson Brown of course, Derry Hall, let's see Derry Hall was playing trombone in that band then. And the band played an exhausting gig at the Deke House and we all fell asleep under the piano. And we awoke several hours later, and I knew they would be hungry. I was the leader of the band so I felt responsible for giving them vittles, and that's another Emerson Brown story, he was snoring along with the rest of them so I decided to go down to Clinton, get a pizza pie, I got two big pies, brought it back, shoved it under the piano and started to kick the soles of their feet, and they said, "Oh my goodness, that smells wonderful, this is terrific, what a smell to wake up to." Everybody was so thankful and appreciative of my initiative in getting this pie, except for Emerson. Emerson's response, and I can remember that after fifty years was, "What, no anchovies?" That's Emerson.

MR: That about sums him up I guess.

DS: Emerson had his drawbacks personality-wise. He was difficult to deal with and I as the leader would try to recruit him every year to play Hamilton reunions and it was like pulling teeth. He wanted to play. He loved playing. But he just put me through a wringer all the time. I would say, "If you can't make it just say no and I'll get someone else." He would keep dragging it out.

DS: He made me work for it.

MR: Yeah.

DS: He had failings. As a leader he was impatient. He didn't look around to see if the drummer's got drumsticks in his hand. He was just too eager to go. But all that aside, nobody liked to play more than he or had more passion for playing than he. So he deserves high marks for that because he inspired everybody around him. He drove himself and he drove the band, so he was a good man. I understand that his widow may be attending.

MR: Yes.

DS: I hope she does.

MR: She's supposed to be here tonight actually. I'm doing an alumni college.

DS: I've know her very well for a long — many, many years. One time I drove up to see Emerson and Cindy, who were living in Syracuse at that time, and they were low on funds and they had a big moose that was hanging on the wall, a moose head. And they took it out and they hocked the moose head so we could buy a steak.

MR: Oh my.

DS: Isn't that something?

MR: Wow.

DS: And then we spent that night at the window of Emerson's apartment, it was on the third floor. The snowflakes were swirling down and I was playing on a snare drum with brushes and he was playing the clarinet out the window. That was the band.

MR: Didn't he used to take a long bike ride?

DS: Oh he rode up from Nashville one time on a bike. His wife would come along with him and they'd stop and eat and she would take care of him.

MR: I'll be darned.

DS: Oh yeah, that's a remarkable thing.

MR: Well you heard me talking with Phil a little bit I think about the music that you were playing. I think it's interesting that, perhaps from my perspective, I had sort of made this assumption that you might have been playing music that was not really what your audience would have chosen to listen to. But I'm getting the sense that I'm wrong.

DS: You're wrong.

MR: Okay.

DS: This is the music that they wanted, that they liked. Remember, there was no Elvis at that time when we started and there was no rock & roll. We were the kings. This is, you go to Eddie Condon's or you go to Nick's and that was the epitome of jazz and of popular music. It was the best. Hot music in its finest flower. And so we had no displeasure from

course by the mid to late fifties rock & roll had come in and started to stifle a demand for Dixieland. We're fortunate there are people as old as we around that liked it at Hamilton. And we're also fortunate, I think Hamilton is, that the younger folks, the younger bands that play more modern music or folk music, are providing that for them. We don't want to be the sole purveyor of music. It's great that there is a choice now between audiences.

MR: Right. So it really is not that much different from a Hamilton band in 1965 playing current music on campus and at other colleges. That's kind of what you were doing.

DS: Yes except we are more proficient now. I heard you say that you noticed there's an improvement in our band. I think we are at the peak of our powers now. That is why we made that Legacy CD. We're not going to play any better I don't think than that.

MR: Yeah. Did you ever have vocalists in the group by choice?

DS: Yes we did. We did. Mike Parker, the son of Paul Parker, was our first trumpeter. And he had wife named Dottie.

MR: I know about that, yes.

DS: And she was the vocalist.

MR: Right. I think I was referring more to back in the Catatonic Five though. Did you have singing?

DS: No.

MR: Okay.

DS: Never sang.

MR: Okay. You know maybe that's what to me distinguishes and is so neat about the fact that you guys did that, is nowadays popular music is so vocal oriented.

DS: Yeah.

MR: I mean you can listen all day to the radio, any station you want, and you hardly ever hear an instrumental.

DS: Right. It's rare.

MR: So for you guys to have an instrumental band back then, I think it's very hip.

DS: Now this is odd that you say that, Monk, because our predecessors, the Fallacious Five, didn't really have vocalists, but they used to, two or three of them, would intone lyrics to jazz type tunes like "She Looks Like Helen Brown." I think you may know that one?

MR: "She Looks Like Hell In Brown?"

DS: Both. [sings] "She looks like Helen Brown/She's the hottest gal in town/When she's dressed in green or gray/Scotsmen throw their kilts away/Oh she looks like hell in brown/She's the hottest gal in town/Oh she looks alright when she's dressed in white/But she looks like hell in brown. That kind of thing.

MR: Okay.

DS: Novelty songs. Novelty songs like that. "Your Engine's Kind of Rusty," you know that one?

MR: No.

DS: Let me overhaul your car? [sings] Your engine's kind of rusty/Cranky, kind of dusty/Let me overhaul your car/Your engine needs a workout/I'll get every quirk out/My repairs are best by far/Say, why don't you let me look under your hood/A pint of my oil will do your engine lots of good/And don't you try and back out/I have got my jack out and we're going to do it/Get out and get under/Oh let me overhaul your car. Always something suggestive.

MR: That's great.

DS: Now in our band you just made me think, and we did have some songs that we sang, like "Sandy Don't Allow no Jazz on Sunday," and the "Coast Guard March," this thing Semperubi Sabbubi. You've heard about that one?

MR: No.

DS: Oh wow. We decided to go Latin and kind of sophomoric but we discovered that the Latin phrase Semperubi Sabbubi can be translated "always wear underwear." So to the tune of "Semper Paratus" we did it.

MR: Okay.

DS: But it wasn't a great success so we dropped it from the act.

MR: I see. And the Marine Corps didn't really adopt it.

DS: No, none of them fought to be recognized by our band. But in the 2004 predecessor of this particular CD the words are all printed out. We had attempted to have a sing-a-long but it was a bomb.

MR: I think I was, Saturday night, I was there.

DS: What a bomb ey? Woo hoo.

MR: Yeah. Seemed like a good idea at the time but—

DS: It was too sophomoric. They didn't want to do that.

MR: Right. Well Phil described some of the going out on weekends and playing on other campuses. I assume you guys did the same thing?

DS: Yes but not to the same extent that the second incarnation of the Catatonic Five. My early incarnation of the Catatonic Five played mostly on the campus. We occasionally played at other colleges. We played at Union on one occasion and this is an example of how the alcohol situation got out of control. Dave Barbour was the pianist and he needed to read music. And our alcoholic consumption had got to a stage where it seemed to be a good idea, since we were playing out on the front lawn of this fraternity house, to set fire to a car that we have illumination and Barbour could read the music. It was an old car but it

was the wrong thing to do, and we had to flee and the police came after us but they never caught us. But anyway.

MR: Much better than stand lights I guess.

DS: It was a flickering — it was a stupid thing.

MR: Uh huh. It must have been hard, because your piano player had to have sheet music, it must have really put a limiting factor on what songs you could play obviously, because he had to have the sheet.

DS: It did. But perhaps he had taken our songs and somebody had scored it. Derry Hall could write music like nobody else and so he could do that. We used to play weirdoes like the "Indian Love Call" and stuff like that. And it would be written out and Barbour would play it. We were not a very good band. We were just an early band.

MR: I see.

DS: The second one, the Fallacious Five was first, we were the second, and then we all graduated or went in the Army and then the Donn Andre-Phil Mead band, the second incarnation, which was a really good band, brought a claim to Hamilton. They really went around internationally under the banner of Hamilton so it was good for the college.

MR: Did the Catatonic Five have any connection to the music department?

DS: Not to the music department, but you might say, well, no. I was starting to think about the Alumni All-Stars, that was Paul Parker who was on the faculty for the art department but not the music department.

MR: Okay.

DS: Well wait a minute. Frank Piano was a Spanish assistant professor here. And he used to come and play tenor with us now and then, the Catatonic Five. But that was the only connection we had with the faculty and the music department. He actually wasn't in the music department, he was in the Romance Language department.

MR: And what's this business about — was it the president of the college at that time didn't want no jazz on Sundays?

DS: Sandy McEwen was a Presbyterian minister who, I don't know it'd be very difficult to think of the things that he did like and approve of, but he certainly didn't like us and approve of us, and he heard we were going to play a jazz session, I think it was at the Deke House. And he said, "No there'll be no jazz on Sundays." So we wrote a song called "Sandy Don't 'Low no Jazz on Sunday" you probably heard it. And it was a favorite of Ellie Wertimer's. She would ask for that all the time. And in those days it was quite popular and we weathered the thing. We actually played it anyway. Dean Tolles was the moderator. He mediated the dispute by interpreting the president McEwen's prohibition as being prohibition of music outside on a Sunday. So we moved it inside and

it was fine. Because he thought it would compete with chapel or something. Anyway. It had a happy ending.

MR: Yeah. What did you do in the service?

DS: I was a radio operator. I was fortunate to have, they called them Classification Specialists, who would interview you, as you are interviewing me, and determine how I would best serve Uncle Sam. It was the time of the Korean War and so you would think that they would exercise a little more wisdom than they did in my case. Well I'll give you an example. This Classification Specialist sits me down and says, "What did you do in civilian life?" I said, "Well I just graduated from Hamilton College. I had a job with Batton, Barton, Durston and Osborne, it's an advertising agency." And he says, "Well we don't need advertising in the Army. What did you actually do?" I said, "Well I wrote radio jingles, 'tune in tonight and hear Jack Benny and Phil Harris and all that.'" "Radio? You're a radio man." Dede det de det. Off I went to the Southeast Signal School and for two years I was a high speed radio operator.

MR: I'll be darned.

DS: Yup.

MR: You said the magic word for him I guess.

DS: Yeah. Radio was it. "He's a radioman."

MR: Speaking of radio—

DS: Yes.

MR: Was it a big part of your hearing music when you grew up?

DS: Yes it was. Remember, it was before television. Television didn't appear in my life until 1952 around the time of the Eisenhower election. And we got a T.V. set over in the DU House and we were really excited. But it was radio. And a few disc jockeys were famous for playing jazz and I would tune in all the time to that. And what you see is the results.

MR: Well I had thrown a few song names at Phil, like the stuff that was getting top 10 airplay in the fifties and you had things, even a Leroy Anderson song, "Blue Tango," "How High the Moon" by Les Paul.

DS: Oh sure.

MR: So those were instrumental.

DS: Oh yes.

MR: So there was that going on but then you had Johnny Ray doing "Cry." Did those kinds of things, Dean Martin, Perry Como, did they appeal to you?

DS: Sure, they were okay. But I didn't really love them the way I love jazz.

MR: Right. And you couldn't play them, I mean it would be that—

DS: Oh no, can you imagine trying to play "Cry?" It would make you cry.

MR: When you got out of Hamilton do you think, did you feel like you had had a bargain at this college? And I'm sort of asking that in the relationship of what it cost back then?

DS: I can't remember what my dad, who was a dentist, and what he paid. It was a few thousand I guess. A bargain. Yeah I think I thought I've gotten an awful lot. I was impressed, the college was small, three or four hundred people when I came up here. And the ratio of faculty to students was terrific. We had some classes with four and five people in it. And loved those teachers, those professors. Paul Parker, who became the pianist in the Alumni All-Stars, was a dear man who became very friendly and he would come down to my house and painted pictures of my boats and things like that. It is a wonderful school. I can't imagine how I could have been as happy or as well prepared for life anyplace, and I loved Dean Tolles. Everybody loved Dean Tolles. He tried to make me a businessman. He thought I would have the talent to go to Harvard business school and make a big splash in the business world. But I knew I didn't have it. So he sent me to Boston to go to Harvard and take some interviews in the Harvard business school. I spent one day. I was supposed to go three days. And after the first day I cut out and I went to Storyville to hear the jazz bands that were playing there. Ruby Braff, you know who Ruby Braff, the cornet? And Sonny Greer was the drummer. What bands. So I had a good time going for my interview but I didn't get asked to go to the school and I didn't want to go.

MR: And were you in a fraternity?

DS: DU. Yes.

MR: What was that life like? Different from fraternities today?

DS: Oh gee I guess so. Yeah. It was, the world revolved around that. Now I was the president of the house. So I had some influence with them and I was a strong advocate of the fraternity system but I changed, Monk. As I grew older I grew more liberal and I became very sympathetic with those young men who were not invited to join fraternities and felt like second class citizens and I thought it was too harmful to them to be worth all that the fraternities brought. Yes they were good. But I am happy to see them become a thing of the past. I think they hurt the young people.

MR: Did you have your meals right in the houses?

DS: Yes.

MR: You had a cook?

DS: In the house. We had a professional cook but our own members were the waiters. It was very sociable, very pleasant. And I certainly was a big fan of fraternities until maybe the last ten years. I thought it over and changed my mind.

MR: Do you think the learning process has changed a lot due to technology?

DS: Oh sure. We were pretty primitive. Remember I said that we didn't get television until 1952 let alone computers. Nobody ever thought what a computer —

MR: Right. And cell phones.

DS: Oh no, no, no. We didn't know what it was. But on the good side we didn't have any drugs. Nobody even knew what marijuana was. We would get pretty drunk on booze but we didn't need any, didn't have any drugs, didn't need any drugs, didn't want any drugs. My son was a Hamilton graduate, class of '78, and he said he smoked pot all the time here.

MR: Uh huh. Did you have another one too?

DS: Yeah I have a daughter, Wendy, class of '85. My son is the class of '78, my daughter is the class of '85. And by that time there was a lot of drugs.

MR: Uh huh. Well my daughter just graduated from here also.

DS: Good, congratulations Monk.

MR: So we're very happy.

DS: Oh good, I'm glad. Yes.

MR: So it's interesting for me because growing up I did not know about Hamilton but I certainly do now.

DS: Where did you come from?

MR: From Rochester.

DS: Okay.

MR: But I ended up in this area and this has been a great experience meeting all my jazz heroes through this project.

DS: It's a great experience for Hamilton to have you, and being a player, I think that is so inspirational.

MR: Well thank you.

DS: To look up there on the stage and there you are.

MR: Well it helps talking to musicians.

DS: Oh yes, oh yes, sure.

MR: Is there a story behind the name Catatonic Five?

DS: Yes. Derry Hall and I were kicking around what name to give this band. He said, "Let's name it the Great Five."

MR: The Great Five.

DS: The Great Five, how can you argue with that? And I had just been studying a little abnormal psychology and I said, "How about the Catatonic Five?" He says, "What is catatonia?" And I said, "It is this state of psychosis which is marked by wax-like immobility interrupted by sudden fits of frenzy." He said, "That's it, we'll name it the

MR: That's terrific. That's good. Well you know there's been plenty of odd band names over the years.

DS: They get odder, now.

MR: Really. They seem odder but you know, at the time you had the Mound City Blues Blowers and those kinds of things. But I like the name, it has a certain ring to it.

DS: Catatonic. Yeah, it's got tonic in it and it's got cat.

MR: Yeah. And you can always change the number in case you have another member.

DS: That's true.

MR: The Catatonic Six has a good ring to it also.

DS: The Catatonic Five Plus.

MR: Did you have a bass player in the group?

DS: Not in the Catatonic Five we didn't.

MR: Not even, no tuba either?

DS: Oh no.

MR: Huh. Interesting.

DS: We just got our tuba in recent years and that was not the Catatonic Five, it's the Alumni All-Stars, which is the band closest to my heart.

MR: Right.

DS: And Gordy is a wonderful tuba player. He goes to tuba camp you know, to learn jazz. Jazz tuba camp.

MR: That's cool. Now the Alumni All-Stars, is there an official first year of their existence?

DS: I don't think there's a definitive year. It's the early fifties. I was the first drummer in the Alumni All-Stars because Paul Parker needed a drummer and he asked me. I was in the Catatonic Five. So he knew I was a drummer. And he said, "Come on, we're going to play the same kind of music." And he had his son, Mike Parker, playing cornet, and another son, Larry, playing bass. And then we were joined by John VonBergen, remember John?

MR: Oh sure.

DS: So we had a bass player. When Larry left we had John VonBergen. And then I got Emerson Brown and then we got Collier and we had a Dixieland band.

MR: Neat. Do you have favorite Dixieland musicians yourself?

DS: Yes. I would say Wild Bill Davison, Bobby Hackett on cornet and on trombone I would say Cutty Cutshall and Lou McGarrity, on clarinet it would be Edmond Hall and let me think, you've got the idea. This is the Eddie Condon type player.

MR: Right, right. Do you make a distinction between New Orleans Dixieland and what came after when it went to Chicago? Does it sound different to you?

DS: Sure. Much different. More refined and it's more of a four-to-the-bar beat. There were a lot of two-beat guys that came from New Orleans with the Preservation Hall type thing. The old style, traditional. Then it went to Chicago and by the time I heard it it was in Manhattan and it was sizzling my ears off, I couldn't go back in time any more than that. I loved it.

MR: Well if a young drummer came to you and said, "They're telling me to play two-beat here. I don't know what to do." What do you tell them.

DS: Wow. If he's telling me that I'd say forget it.

MR: Really. Find a different bunch of guys?

DS: Yeah. My drummers were — the most primitive one was my drum teacher in 1949 or '50 I guess, Tony Spargo. He was the drummer with the Original Dixieland Jazz Band.

MR: You took lessons from Tony Spargo?

DS: Yup. Five dollars an hour, and he would come to my house and I had to provide tea for his wife.

MR: I see.

DS: And after about three or four lessons Tony said, "You can keep time, I'm not going to take your money anymore." He said, "Just travel light, keep your ears open, and you'll do fine." So that was my first teacher, it wasn't very technically advanced. But then my favorite drummers were George Wettling with Condon, Buzzy Drootin and the great Cliff Leeman. Those were my idols. Keeping time, keeping time.

MR: Keeping time.

DS: Keeping time. Bill Crow, the great bass player and humorist, he used to make tee shirts that said, "So many drummers, so little time." I'm sure you know that.

MR: That's a good one. He played here one year for Fallcoming.

DS: Oh good man.

MR: Yeah. A very interesting guy. Tell me about John Ibach a little bit.

DS: John Ibach was a beloved member of our band. I served on the Student Council with him as an undergraduate. He was a very fervent player, very passionate about it. And he has done a lot for jazz piano in Florida, he was known as Dr. Jazz in Jacksonville, and he sponsored some Marian McPartland concerts. He was well known by professionals and by audiences. But we loved him. He was a funny guy. And a dear man, a truly kind man. And we really missed him. I saw him a couple of times down in Florida when he was starting to get ill and it was cruel because his mind was so good. He was an extremely intelligent man, a great surgeon. So I miss him. That's all I can say about him.

MR: Do you see replacements in line for the All-Stars?

DS: I don't. But you never can tell. Now Bill Semple is the class of '68. When Emerson

from ’68 replacing a guy from ’56. So it’s always possible. I hope they will, I hope they’ll find them.

MR: What’s the jazz scene like in New York City now?

DS: Oh for my kind of music it’s pretty dim, dismal. There’s the Cajun at Eighth Avenue and Sixteenth Street where they always have some Dixieland band and I get hired as a substitute down there a lot. But outside of that, and Arthur’s Tavern, those are the only two places that have Dixieland now.

MR: And you live where?

DS: I live in Long Island in East Islip Long Island, it’s about fifty miles out from New York City.

MR: So I’m fairly spoiled in this area you know, in fact one of the gigs I play as a pianist —

DS: Oh I forgot you play piano.

MR: Yeah. I actually work more as a piano player these days, and I play the Hotel Utica, and I literally can leave my house 15 minutes before the job, and unless I run into a stoplight I can sit down at the piano in time to start. But for you, with a drumset, to go into Manhattan—

DS: No the drumset’s there. Oh, oh, these other jobs like the Cajun and Arthur’s, yes I bring it in there. That’s a struggle.

MR: Yeah. Finding a parking spot and all that. You probably have to leave like—

DS: Yeah and I get paid twenty-five dollars for it. You know.

MR: You’ve got to love it.

DS: Yeah. But I do it to help out and to play with these guys that I love.

MR: Right.

DS: These are my buddies from my band, they’re all in other bands. Lee Lorenz is one, he’s called me a few times, the great cartoonist. The next time you see the *New Yorker*, take a look for Lee Lorenz.

MR: You ever run into Sol Yaged?

DS: Yes. Sol used to come every once in a while, drop in to our concerts down at the Donnell Library.

MR: Yeah. Who do you listen to these days?

DS: I listen to old CDs.

MR: Reissues.

DS: Bobby Hackett, did I mention him? I hope so.

MR: Yeah.

DS: I love him. He’s a nice contrast. I play a little bit of him and then a little bit of Wild Bill Davison. And on the average I’m okay. It’s like the fellow who stands on one bare foot

MR: Yeah. Interesting. Yeah I think it was another Bill Crow story about Bobby Hackett selling one of his trumpets and he said "high register never used."

DS: That's right. And somebody once said to him, and this was on a radio interview, "Bobby you're known for never having a bad word about anybody. Praise, yes, but you'll never criticize anybody. So what if somebody said 'Adolph Hitler?'" So Bobby thinks a minute and he says, "Well I guess you'd have to say that he was tops in his line."

MR: Wow. Well one thing you said about the band and this CD, our jazz does not rely on arrangements or even preparatory discussions before we swing into a tune.

DS: Well that's true. I can't believe it but that's what it is. We have a beautiful rapport in the band, we have fine leadership. Marty just says, "Okay we're going to do this" and then one-two, off we go. And then for the endings, every once in a while he'll throw a firehouse ending in on you and you just have a keep listening and you can watch him. Sometimes the bell of his horn will come up a little bit or his eyebrow will arch. You can tell.

MR: Okay now you just used a term that I'm not familiar with. A firehouse ending?

DS: Oh an extended, another four bars. Instead of just ending after four bars after the drum break, they're going for eight bars.

MR: Okay.

DS: That's a firehouse ending. I taught you something. I can't believe it.

MR: Thank you. I will be prepared next time, in fact I'm going to use it, I'm going to use that firehouse. That's cool. I wonder where that came from?

DS: I don't know. I don't know. That's interesting to find out, the origin of the phrase.

MR: One time I had played with this veteran fiddler, Claude "Fiddler" Williams.

DS: Oh yes.

MR: And he said, we were playing the song, we were playing like an Ellington song and we were almost done, and he said to the band, he goes, "Channel." He said, "Channel."

DS: Uh oh.

MR: Uh oh is right, we didn't know what he meant. And he meant the bridge. Channel, as in English Channel, or that was his term for the bridge and he wanted to go back to the bridge.

DS: Wow. I never heard that, Monk.

MR: Yeah, an older term.

DS: And I'm old. Somebody said, "How old is your band." I said well our band is over 50 years old, and I'm the elderstatesman you might say. I have the second — we're long in the tooth — I have the second longest set of teeth in the band. He says, "Well who has the longest ones?" "Well" I said, "We have a 75-year-old bassist named Bob Abrams,

he's out somewhere auditioning for the lead role in a Dracula production. You know what a sweet man he is.

MR: Yes he surely is.

DS: What a neat guy.

MR: He seems to be in a happy time in his life right now and I'm very pleased.

DS: It is and he's made such tremendous progress on the bass.

MR: And he's got a real one now too.

DS: A real stand-up bass.

MR: Which I really like.

DS: Yeah I do too.

MR: There's nothing like it.

DS: I agree. He likes it too now.

MR: It's a pain to travel around with but you know about that.

DS: I know.

MR: You always bring your own drums to this gig, right?

DS: Always. And as a pianist you know how bad it can be if you're going to a gig and the piano hasn't been tuned or it's got a couple of sticking keys. At least when you bring your own drums you know they're good. So I'm luckier than many pianists.

MR: Yeah, close enough for jazz, I think that's where the term came from.

DS: Yeah. Not so much fun.

MR: This is a little off the track but what do you feel about the — this is a very small question — state of the country today.

DS: Oh that's an interesting question. My background is I've always been a Republican and a supporter of Republicans. But I didn't vote for President Bush in the last election, I did it the first time. Because I am fed up with him and I think he did a terrible thing to our country. I think we have frittered away the credit that we had with other nations. I think the country is in very bad shape and I attribute it to President Bush. And I didn't vote for him the last time and I certainly wouldn't — well he's a lame duck now so. But I'm very sad about it. And you know what it does, Monk? It makes me think about the great countries who had leadership roles like Greece and Rome, and now I'm afraid we're going that route. I think we're in a downturn.

MR: Yeah because they went down the tubes eventually.

DS: They did. But our music is happy music and it makes me happy and it makes the people happy. So to get back to jazz.

MR: Yeah, yeah. Even when you play a ballad it's happy.

DS: Oh yeah.

MR: Right, well just to wrap up, I've been always impressed by the loyalty and passion of Hamilton alums, the ones that don't have it I haven't met, so, you know, but the ones that I have, starting with Milt Fillius and I go what is it about this place that inspires that kind of loyalty.

DS: It's not one thing it's a combination of things. There's a beauty of the physical plant — you have the campus and Root Glen and things second to none. You have I think a marvelous faculty, in my day you did, and I think that we had a good administration, we had Winton Tolles. So the people who went to college in my day at Hamilton loved the college. They were enthusiastic then and as alums they become very enthusiastic. You'll see them howling with delight when they hear our band playing.

MR: Well that's great. And some of that hasn't changed because when I hear my daughter talk to other people about the college she will say that. She'll say, "Oh, I loved Hamilton."

DS: I'm interested in what is her response. What were the elements that she praised?

MR: You know I'm not sure yet because she won't say it to my wife and I as much as she will to another person. But she loved the camaraderie. I think she benefited from rubbing elbows with people from other socioeconomic strata — whatever you want to call that.

DS: Yeah.

MR: And she was an RA for three years so she learned a great deal about responsibility.

DS: Interesting. Maybe she'll come forth with some more opinions after she has aged a little bit.

MR: I'm sure she will.

DS: You seem to be a happy man here at Hamilton.

MR: Well you know one thing, this has been a dream gig for me, and Milt Fillius used to joke, he wasn't joking, he used to put in a joke, he said, "I wanted the job that I gave to you." He made this whole interview thing possible, and since then I've met so many of my musical heroes, and it's been a great job for me.

DS: What a good way to look at it.

MR: And he wanted to do it.

DS: I'm glad you got it.

MR: Yeah, okay.

DS: I don't know how good he would have been. He probably would have been fine but —

MR: He did sit in on a few early on. We interviewed Mona Hinton, Milt Hinton's wife, together, and a couple others. And he probably — he was a very opinionated man, about his musical tastes, so if he didn't like something he was not good at disguising it.

DS: I gathered that, yes.

MR: But he has a good legacy. So I want to thank you for your conversation today.

MR: Anything you want to add before we head on to your dinner and so forth?

DS: No, I'd like to add nothing except thanks to you and for what you're doing for the college, the Jazz Archive deserves everybody's support.

MR: Great. Appreciate it. And I look forward to playing with you this weekend.

DS: Hey good. We won't forget that. We are going to hold you to that.

MR: One of these days I'm going to get one of those straw hats. I don't know how many years I have to put in but —

DS: Uh, is the interview over now?

MR: I don't know, we could still be rolling.

DS: It doesn't make any difference. I'm having a minor rebellion by the band.

MR: Oh.

DS: I've always insisted that the straw hats be worn. And it's been, I think a boon to us because our publicity is very good. The pictures of us in the *Alumni Review* for example with the hats on are terrific, it's a uniform thing. But lately I'm getting a lot of resistance to wearing the hats. And two sources. Gordy Bourns says, "When I wear the hat I can't play the tuba, the tuba hits it." And Phil Mead, his trombone slide hits the hat. And that is absolutely right, those are justifiable complaints. So what we'll do, I've told them that you don't have to wear the hats except when we're being photographed. That's the impression that I want to convey to readers of the *Alumni Review*, that we're a uniformed band and all. So I'm going to talk about it tonight with them at our little dinner. But I have this — the people who come to hear us at Hamilton, be it the reunion class that we're playing for at the banquet or people at the cookout or anyplace, I think they are not that impressed by the fine degree of improvement in our music over last year, but they are impressed by the uniformed appearance with the straw hats. And we may think we can play better, and something we do, but I don't think the audience hears much of that really, to tell you the truth. I think we're playing as well as we're ever going to play. So I say, "Please put the hats on when the photographer is out there clicking.

MR: Yeah. I agree.

DS: But for the guys that have this physical disability, they can't play their horn, you've got to be — they're not getting paid, they come up here and they do this for nothing every year, and I want to make it as easy for them.

MR: Yeah. It doesn't want to become annoying. All right. Well say hi to the rest of the fellas for me.

DS: I'm going to tell them it was not bad.

MR: Yeah all right.

DS: I'll scare Donny Andre and I'll say, "Wait until you get your chance to do this." That was